

Lecture 3

3.1 Main Idea

Good morning. Is anyone joining us today who was not here previously? I know one of you—anyone else joining us? Good. 😊 I won't see you guys next week thanks to the holiday; I'll see you in two weeks. So I know it says "next week" here, but it just means next class. Read the handbook for next class, 2.4—that's the part on our claims.

And the other thing I'd like you to read for the next class is the essay called *Kill the Language Requirement*. This essay is by Gavin Schiff, where he argues that Yale should get rid of the language requirement. It's a very, very good example of structure. Two things I really want to focus on: framing—using values in framing—and concessions. Do you remember what a concession is? I mentioned it last week. Yeah, "my opponents would say this is why I'm wrong." He has one, two, three, four concessions. So I really want to look at those in the next class as well.

3.1.1 Policy

Anyway, today we're talking about the main idea. This is part of the introduction. You can choose any topic you like for the first essay, and you can choose any topic you like for the second essay. For the third essay, you must disagree with an author. There are a range of options that you have to pick from a list. And for the final exam, you will be given the topic—so, you know, health, education, technology, whatever—but you can choose your own main idea within that topic. That's what we'll practice doing in the second period today.

But for the first essay, any topic is totally fine. If you want to write about a topic related to your own major, that's great. If you want to write about a topic at the very local level, you can do that. I've even had students argue that, you know, my Patrick's class policy should be changed, right? You want to bring it to a very narrow level. But you can argue about school policy, like next week's essay; you can argue about city policy, national policy, international policy—any level is fine, as long as you meet the criteria that we're going to talk about in today's class.

You must do policy for the first essay. In the second essay, it's totally up to you—you can do policy, you can do value, you can do fact. In the first essay, you must propose policy. Okay, so do not disagree with a policy. Do not argue, "Fudan should abolish the 30% A rule," for instance, okay? But you can think about that problem that Fudan has with grade inflation and propose your own policy. So instead of a 30% A rule, Fudan should have some other policy that deals with it. So you must propose policy. Can anyone think of other Fudan policies that we see? There's the 30% A rule—what are some other policies?

Yeah, **compulsory PE**. I do actually ban that topic because it's so popular. When I first taught this class, I didn't realize, and I got so many essays from students arguing that Fudan students should not have to do PE class. So I usually say don't do that topic because it's way too common.

Gate policy. You know, only students and staff can enter the campus. **Dorm policy**, you know, you must live in the same dorm as your major, right? You know, if you're a medical student, you live with other medical students. Is that right? Chinese language students live with other Chinese language students. You know, they put the majors together in the same dormitory—not if you're a foreign student, but right, if you're a foreign student, you have the foreign student dorm. And I've heard students arguing about this before as well, that foreign students should have to live in Chinese dorms with Chinese students. So these are some examples of policy.

Can you think of any verbs? You know, when we have policy, it's an action—it's something we should do, right? Can you think of common policy verbs? 🤔 I often hear verbs students use that are not very clear, right? Like "blame" or "reflect on," and this type of thing—and it's not really clear what that means, is it? Or "improve"—"we must improve something"—and I think, well, how? How are we going to improve it?

Can you think of clear verbs that we use in policy? Well, we should limit the number of A grades a class can receive, right? That's a clear verb. Can you think of any others? You know, you enforce the policy, but how can anyone enforce it? Another very common example would be **tax**. You know, we should tax fast food; we should tax X , make it more expensive. Or the opposite of tax—**subsidize** (资助). That means you get money for doing it. You know, in some countries, if you turn in glass bottles, they will give you money. We should subsidize recycling, for example. Can you think of any others? **Punish**. You know, people who do X should be punished, right? Students who are caught cheating in an exam should be arrested and punished by the law. These are just some basic examples.

3.1.2 Originality

So let me start. Do you guys understand the principle of **diminishing marginal returns**? Diminishing marginal returns, as it comes from economics? Remember last week we talked about **comparative advantage**. This is another economic principle—diminishing marginal returns. If I give you the first slice of cake, that tastes great—you're hungry, it's really good. The second slice of cake, you continue to enjoy it, but maybe not as much. The third slice of cake, now you don't really want more cake. The fifth slice of cake, now you feel sick. The tenth slice of cake, now you feel terrible, right? So the more of something you have, for each extra unit, the impact diminishes—diminishing marginal returns.

If you study one hour in the library, you learn a lot. If you study two hours in the library, you might learn twice as much. If you study ten hours in the library, do you learn ten times as much? Probably not. If you study twenty hours in the library, each extra hour may actually harm your learning because you're so tired you forget what you studied. So diminishing marginal returns.

I think diminishing marginal returns also applies to topic selection. If you are the very first person to argue for something, your impact on that topic could be very big. If you are the hundredth person to argue for it, not so much. If you are the millionth person to argue for it, your marginal contribution is close to zero—so you're really not making any difference. 🤔

So the main rule I have—the number one rule I have—for the first essay is: **do not take a standard position in an existing debate**. Do not take a standard position in an existing debate. These are things that you hear argued often. You might find examples on, you know, 知乎, the website, right? Do not simply go to 知乎, find a hot topic, and argue for or against it. That is very much taking a standard position in an existing debate.

"Should Fudan abolish PE classes?" Maybe you think yes, maybe you think no, but this is very much taking a standard position in an existing debate. What I encourage students to do instead is to try and think about the problem behind the debate, right? Don't think about policy by thinking about policy. **Try to think about policy by thinking about problems.**

So if you've got Group A and Group B: Group A thinks that we should legalize gay marriage; Group B thinks we should not legalize gay marriage, right? If you say "legalize gay marriage" or "don't legalize gay marriage," you are taking a standard position in an existing debate.

I've asked this before, but I'll ask it again: can you think of any other standard debates or existing debates with standard positions? What do you hear argued for and against a lot?

- Yeah, AI. So should we rush to develop AI or hold back on developing AI. If you took position A or B there, that would be an existing debate. Any others?
- Well, slavery? I mean, that debate is over, isn't it? Because nobody has one side—no one's pro-slavery (支持奴隶制的), right? That side won the debate. There's an economist called Paul Krugman, a Nobel Prize-winning economist, and he calls these "zombie ideas," right? He says some debates have been won, but people still hold on to them. Climate change, for example—is climate change real? The science shows it's clearly real, but there are still some people who have this zombie idea, this dead idea that has lost the debate, that climate change isn't real, even though we can see it outside every day, right? 🤖

Anyway, don't take position A or position B. Try to think about the problem—what's going on behind the debate? Why are we having this debate? Then try to think of a different solution—pull the rope sideways. Try to think of positions C. How could you solve that problem in a different way? It doesn't have to be a perfect or really feasible idea. I'm looking for original ideas, okay? That's what we're doing in this class—we're practicing thinking of original ideas. Because your contribution—your marginal contribution—will be much bigger if you make an original contribution to the debate.

So again, back to last week's example about immigration: more immigration, less immigration, abolishing borders—that's position A and B. Or what have I said? People should have a free market in citizenship. If I have Irish citizenship and somebody from Africa wants to buy my Irish citizenship for two million dollars, I should be allowed to sell it to someone from Africa. They get to live in Ireland, and I get their citizenship, but I also get the money. Is that a good idea? You might disagree. Have you heard it before? No. That's pulling the rope sideways.

Should we have higher taxes? Should we have lower taxes? Or what have I said—let's tax IQ. Everyone takes an IQ test; if their IQ is very high, maybe their tax rate goes up. Or tax height—people who are very tall, or men who are very tall, they pay a higher tax rate. Or anything like that. These are political thought experiments.

So again, don't think about the policy, don't think about the existing debate. Think about problems first. Try to think about how you could solve those problems without taking a standard position in an existing debate.

Can you think of any problems here at Fudan? You must be able to. I'm sure you don't consider your life to be perfect. No, Fudan is not a school without problems. 😊 Okay, PE classes. I had a student in the other class propose this as well. They said students should be free to test in any sport. So it shouldn't just be the one assigned to you. If you're good at basketball or swimming or cycling, you should be allowed to test in any sport. I think foreign students don't have to do PE—is that right? No PE requirement? So that's very unfair—inequality.

But what's the problem, right? Before there was PE class at Fudan, why did they think that policy was necessary? Do you guys know why Britain first had PE classes? We had a war in South Africa in 1901—you don't need to know the history—but the war got so bad that they had to call up. They had to conscript people who weren't in the army and force them to join and go fight in the war. And it turned out the soldiers were terrible because they were really unfit and unhealthy. And the government decided we cannot let this happen again. If we fight another war, we need strong, fit, healthy soldiers. So we must make all school students do PE class. That's why Britain first adopted PE.

Why does Fudan adopt PE? Why do Chinese schools adopt PE? Is it the same reason? You know that in China you have compulsory military training, right, for students? Of course, they don't teach you how to kill a man with your hands. It's just marching and suffering from the sunshine. 🌞

I mean, the obvious answer to my question, I suppose, is that students are unhealthy or students are overweight, right? Could you find some other solution to that problem? Isn't PE class—you know, I think Fudan does have lots of sports facilities. If you want to go swimming at Fudan, you can easily go swimming, right? There are lots of activities you can do at Fudan.

So talk to each other and try to think about problems that you see at Fudan or in 杨浦. Ask yourself: is there a policy that already tries to deal with it, okay? But more importantly, is there some solution you can think of that we don't normally see? So, for example, overcrowding on the campus. Too many people coming into Fudan campus and making a mess. So the policy now is that you must have an appointment to enter Fudan campus. But what have I said? Fudan should sell tickets. If you want to enter Fudan campus, arrive at the gate, pay 300 RMB, and you can enter the campus for 24 hours with that ticket, right? Do you think that's a good policy?

It would keep numbers down because, you know, the grandmother who lives next door to Fudan—she's not going to pay 300 RMB every day to push the pram around Fudan campus, right? But it would still allow some people who really want to, like tourists who come from far away, to look around the Fudan campus. And it would raise money, so Fudan would have extra cash to spend on improving the environment.

So try and think of a problem that you see at Fudan or in 杨浦 District, and then try and think of a solution—not a solution that already exists, but some novel solution. Take five minutes and I'll get some answers. Just work in a group.

(FIVE MINUTES LATER...)

All right then, let's hear some ideas.

- Start with you, then. What did you think? Playing with your phone guarantees you'll be asked first. 🙄
Can you give us a problem? Yeah, food. So I'm sure probably everyone agrees that the food isn't great, or could be better. And can you propose a solution? I heard this one in the other class, and the student actually had a pretty interesting solution, but I'll ask you for yours first—or anyone. So the student in the other class said Fudan students should have discounts in restaurants in 五角场, right? So if you're a Fudan student with a Fudan card and you go to 五角场, you should get like 20 or 30 percent off in local restaurants. You could go and eat in 西贝 and enjoy better food than the canteen.

Yeah, teachers should be asked to eat in the canteen once a week—once a month. Okay, so make the teachers choose the student seats, and then they will complain more. Yeah. Did anyone think of other ideas to improve students' eating experience? I thought the one about discounts was quite an interesting original idea. I'd never heard that before.

- Did any of you think of any other problems? Yong, is it?

Yong: Fudan's new course selection system has many bugs. 🙄

So it's difficult to choose courses. Can you think of any solution?

Yong: They should ask some of the students to use the new system first and get feedback before releasing it. Meanwhile, they should use the original system as backup.

Yeah, like beta testing. So the new version is the problem.

- Okay, this group—did you guys discuss? Tell us the problem you got. Yeah, every teacher has their own grading standards. Some teachers may give better grades than others. What you could do—this is me thinking just now—is get all the grades from all the teachers and put them through an algorithm so they have the same average grade. So students who are unfairly high or unfairly low would be brought up or brought down slightly, so the average grade is equal. I don't know—maybe students wouldn't like that. I

don't think students want teachers to be fair; I think they want teachers to be generous, right? Yeah, some kind of algorithm or technical solution to that problem might exist.

- You guys? Yeah, another problem is limited study space, especially at the end of the semester. Could you think of a solution? We should add more study space in dorm buildings, so students can study there. I think Fudan doesn't have a lights-out policy, does it? Some schools do. It's like being in prison, right? They turn off the lights at one or something like that. But you could study in the dorm, though your roommates wouldn't be happy.

And yeah, clash of deadlines. It's tricky, because as a teacher you teach everything at the beginning of the semester and set assignments, and they have to be due at the end. But all teachers do that, so all assignments are at the end and students are burnt out at the end of the semester.

3.1.3 Clear SODA

In the first class this morning, another student proposed that Fudan should begin classes at 9 a.m. instead of 8 a.m. That's probably quite an interesting one—or even 10 a.m. I think it's Argentina—I read about this policy. They allow high school students to choose whether to attend classes in the morning or in the afternoon. They can choose either one. Science suggests that teenagers don't sleep like normal adults—they sleep later and wake up later. High school students need more sleep. Students shouldn't have to study at 8 a.m. I don't think China will ever have that policy.

Yes, I think talking about time policies can be fine, but if you do, make sure that it is **significant**. Like if I say, "Fudan should start classes at 8:30"—that might not really be a very big change. You know what I mean? Half an hour extra in bed isn't going to make a big difference. So make sure you're proposing something significant, generally speaking.

Also, think about your conclusion. I think I said this last week: if you can't say something meaningful at the end of the essay, that is not a very good essay. Make sure your main idea is significant for that reason. Like if I say my policy is to change the sound the bell plays, right—what's the conclusion going to say? It's hardly "I have a dream," right? It's not very inspiring. So make sure your main idea is significant.

A very popular one I saw a few years ago: a lot of students wrote essays arguing that we should not give one-star reviews to delivery drivers, you know, 美团 or 饿了么. We should not give them one-star reviews. And I thought, yeah, it's not that significant, right? You know, "I have a dream of a better tomorrow where all delivery drivers have a high rating"—it's not really that significant.

Make sure your main idea is **original**. That's really what we've been talking about this morning. Do not take a standard position in an existing debate. I'm not asking that you be the very first person to ever argue something, but if it's something we see argued a lot, don't do it.

I would also caution you: don't take a policy from another country and just say China should have it, right? Don't say China should have this policy from America. In the last class, I had a student—she wrote that the 高考 policy for 浙江 should be the policy for all of China. And I can't really give you credit for being creative if you say that, because all you've done is look at the policy in 浙江 and say China should have that policy in the whole country.

So try to actually think of an idea yourself. I'm not asking that you check—I'm not saying that you have to go and check whether any country in the world has this policy. It's fine, don't worry too much about it. But if it's a well-known, famous policy, try to think of something more original. We are just practicing in this class.

But I do think this is good advice for the future. When you go into your job and people think in rigid ways—on side A or side B of something—if you can think of a third option that people aren't usually talking about, that could break the deadlock, that could change everything. So it is a good way of thinking. Also in IELTS exams—I have friends who grade IELTS exams—they tell me this is the most annoying thing for them. They say most students write one thing or the other, for or against. Very few students write original answers for their IELTS writing.

Make sure it's **debatable**. Would reasonable people disagree with you? If everybody already agrees with you, you don't need to persuade anyone. So don't do it that way. On the other hand, if everybody would be really angry with you for writing this, you should probably also reconsider. I had a student once who argued that American colleges should separate Black and white students. And I said to him, if you wrote that in an American school—if you handed that in—you'd probably be in big trouble. 🙄 You might get kicked out. Your classmates would all hate you for writing something like that. So just be careful. Some topics are a little bit taboo, and race is quite taboo.

Can you think of any other taboo topics? Yeah, in certain places, religion. Says again?

Yong: Nazi 🙄

Yeah, the history of World War II and Nazi Germany—stuff like that. A couple of years ago I was teaching English majors in a debate class, and it was when Joe Biden and Donald Trump were competing for president. I made them debate whether America should have an age limit for the president. Some of them refused to debate it. I realized why—it's not a very safe topic. So don't get yourself in trouble.

I'm not going to show your essays to anybody—they're just for me. But in the final exam, obviously those are kept at the school. So don't write a topic that would get you in trouble, and don't write a topic that would get me in trouble. 🙄 That's the most important thing I would say.

Certain topics—you don't need to persuade people. For example, I hear students argue things like: we should do more exercise, we should eat healthier food, we should pay doctors more, or we should pay scientists more. Would anyone disagree? If I said we should pay scientists more, would anyone say no, I'm against paying doctors more? Everyone agrees. So why don't we pay doctors more? Because we don't have enough money to afford it.

I heard a student argue that Fudan should build a tunnel over 邯郸 Road. Everyone thinks that's a great idea, right? So why don't we do it? Lack of money, probably. We just don't have the resources. Or like the one you mentioned earlier: the dorms should have study rooms. I think everyone would agree—who doesn't want a study room in the dorm? But why don't we have them? Probably because we can't afford it. Why don't we eat healthy food? Because we choose unhealthy food—we prefer it. Why don't we do more exercise? Nobody needs to be persuaded that exercise is good for their health, right? Why don't you smoke cigarettes? We all know it's bad for our health. Nobody needs to be persuaded that smoking is unhealthy.

So make sure it's something that average people would disagree with, and make sure it's **attractive**. Here I mean: don't write for people in your major. For instance, if you're a medical student and you argue that doctors should use this medical device instead of that medical device in this medical procedure, I won't have a clue what you're talking about. So write for a general audience. Assume your readers are smart but ignorant. They can understand it if it's explained, but they don't have a background in economics, engineering, or medicine.

Don't write something that only people with a special major can understand. If I learn a new word from your essay, that is a bad thing. Some students think, "Oh, the teacher can learn a new word." No. If I don't know that word and I have to go on Google, that's your problem. If I'm on Google because of your essay, you have a problem with your essay, okay?

I consider myself a reasonably well-educated native English speaker. If I haven't heard a word before, that probably means the average English speaker wouldn't know that word either. Don't try to impress me with big jargon words. We'll say more about this in week seven. Make sure the essay could be read by any smart, ignorant person.

3.1.4 Examples

Just to show you a few examples—I used to give this as an assignment, I don't now because of AI. But here are some main ideas. We'll do this next week. I'll give you some main ideas and try to get you to think of claims to support them.

For example, here's some context: *the US is a large country with a low population density and a top destination for immigration*. Here's the main idea: *the US should aim to increase its population to one billion by around 2070*. What's the topic here? Immigration. We've all heard arguments for and against immigration. Has anyone heard the argument that America should aim for a population of one billion? Probably not. It's not a common one.

Another example: *taxes on fatty foods only discourage occasional consumers while doing little to dissuade heavy consumers*. China doesn't have this policy, right? There's no sugar tax, no fat tax. You can buy cola and it's very cheap. The exact same product costs five times more in the UK. *These policies should remain, but we should also begin to tax people based on their BMI*. Have you heard that policy before? You might have if you've taken a debate class. You all know BMI? They use your height and your weight to calculate your BMI. So if your BMI is over 25, you should be fine, you know. Have you heard that argument before? Probably not, right?

During COVID, vaccines were slowed down because medical ethics prevent subjects from being infected with a virus. You could not take COVID and inject someone with COVID, right? The doctor would be punished for doing that, right? *The rules should change to allow people who give consent to be deliberately infected with viruses during vaccine trials*. I don't think anyone's heard that before, have they? Hopefully not.

You've definitely heard this one before. *LLMs like ChatGPT have made homework obsolete*. Teachers should change the syllabus to grade students entirely on work completed in the classroom. You've heard that one before? No? Well, that's what we're going to do after the break. I'm going to grade you on work completed in the classroom. 🙄 I won't tell you what the topics are. I'll show you after the break. So I will ask you to put away phones, put away computers—no DeepSeek—and just use your brains to try and think of some main ideas. Does anyone need paper? I've got some spare sheets here. If anyone needs paper, just help yourself. Hopefully you've all got pens.

3.2 Exercise

(AFTER THE BREAK...)

I'll just quickly check the seating chart to see who's missing. We've got Grace, all right. Yong and Zen—yes. And Emily, and Cecilia, and HY, Eric, Stephen, and Scott. Do we have Leo? Anyway, don't worry too much about this exercise. It's just pass/fail. You're either here or you're not here, right? So I don't mind how well you do. Making mistakes is good. If you make mistakes, we can learn from those. So don't worry too much—just try your best.

The goal here is quality, not quantity. In the previous class, lots of students were trying to write as much as they could. I'm not saying, "Good job, you wrote 300 words." Just try to write something like this: maybe one sentence of context or the problem, and then one sentence that says, you know, *X* should do *Y*, or "should" plus a verb. Just try to make it a clear main idea.

Try to use the process that we spoke about: think about the problem, then think about possible solutions that we don't currently see, and try to be clear. That's the other thing—clarity. Use clear verbs. Don't say "we should reflect on" or "we should do more to help" or something like that. Make it a concrete action that you think we should take. Any questions?

So your topics are—this was the previous class (Education & Health)—you guys get crime or gender. So think about problems with crime or public security or gender, and then try to think of a solution that's a policy. I will give you 15 minutes. When it's finished, I will gather up your main ideas, and I will get this side of the class to evaluate that side of the class, and vice versa. You've got 15 minutes. I'll give you until seven minutes past eleven. Go ahead.

(FIFTEEN MINUTES LATER...)

Make sure, if you wrote on your own paper, that it's torn off so you can give it to others. I'll just get this sign-in sheet first. It's just an exercise, and I will ask you to evaluate the ideas you get using this criteria: is it clear, is it significant, is it original, is it debatable, is it attractive? You can mark them like that. If you think it's not clear, write "C." If you think it's not original, write "O." I'm not asking you to give it a grade or a pass or fail—just feedback.

So here, you guys group up as one big group. You guys are another group. I'll maybe ask you to give me the title of your best idea. My advice is to discuss them together. Like I say, talk to each other, because you might get better ideas from others.

(FIVE MINUTES LATER...)

Okay, so just read out each one and then tell me whether you think it has any of those problems or whether you think it's very good. Let's start with this group here. Just read it out and then tell us what you think. How about HY—can you read one out first?

HY: According to Foucault's theory, prisons were created to legitimize the power of the king in the first stage. But when it comes to an ideally democratic society, should we abolish prisons and replace them with moral education and technical training?

What do you think about that? Abolishing prisons is pretty original. I guess it's maybe more than one thing, because it has "abolish prisons" and "replace them with moral education and technical devices." That might be okay, but it could be a bit big for the first essay. But certainly, if you narrow it down to just abolishing prisons, I think that would be quite good. Did you see any other issues with it?

HY: No.

Yeah, I like it. I think that's good. I'd be quite happy with that. The student came to me with an outline, and that was the main idea. I said, okay, interesting, but narrow it—it's maybe too big for a first essay. Cecilia?

Cecilia: Recently, an incident has intensified public debate on women's rights and gender relations in China, in which a male undergraduate was unfairly accused of sexual harassment by a female student at Wuhan University. I believe the people behind all of this are countries who want to corrupt China from the inside. The Chinese authorities should conduct a thorough investigation and bring the matter to a clear conclusion.

What do you think?

Cecilia: I think it is attractive, but...

Yeah, I guess it kind of is two things as well. You're arguing the fact that it is happening, and then you're arguing what should be done about it. Don't establish facts in the essay—only argue on established facts. And I don't think, I mean, that sounds to me, I don't know anything about this, but is there real evidence that that's happening? To me, it sounds a bit like an internet conspiracy group, right? I don't know, but it doesn't sound like there's definitive proof that that's the cause. So yeah, firstly, you only do one thing in the main idea—don't do two things. Secondly, don't establish facts about that. Eric?

Eric: In many cases, people diagnosed with mental illness may be exempt from criminal responsibility for murder. However, criminals with mental illness should still be held accountable.

What do you think? I think punishment can often make good topics—how to punish people. A couple of years ago, I had a student argue in a speech that people who commit murder should be sent to Xinjiang to plant trees, so that was quite interesting. This one maybe isn't so original—just like "punish them."

Another topic I see like that a lot is arguing that young people, like teenagers, should be punished as adults, right? Because there was that case in 邯郸 where three boys killed their classmate, and that became a very hot topic. Students wanted to argue that 14-year-olds should be punished like 18-year-olds. Maybe not too original. Scott?

Scott: We actually know that job opportunities should just be offered to one gender. Different genders should compete for different jobs.

Okay, wow. What do you think? I mean, I'm not encouraging you to be extremists, but usually I see the opposite problem. Nine times out of ten, I'm telling students to be more debatable. That's actually good. You could use that in your first essay. Steven?

Steven: Many young females find it harder to get a job. They fail to get jobs compared with males of the same age and education level because they may get pregnant and have fewer working years than males. So the solution is that companies should offer equal opportunities to females, which is as long as being a couple.

What do you think?

Steven: I think the idea is great, but it's a little difficult to make it realistic.

Don't worry too much about feasibility in the first essay. Last week's essay was also very difficult to make come true. It's just about having ideas. One thing I would say, though, is that I do actually see that topic quite a lot—the topic about maternity leave, paternity leave, holidays for mothers, holidays for fathers. I've seen that a few times before. I wouldn't say it's a very hot topic, but I've definitely seen it five or six times in the past. So I like the area, the problem is a good one, but I would encourage students to think a bit more originally. Emily?

Emily: Companies tend to choose males compared to people with the same abilities because women are more likely to spend more time away from work when they become mothers. The government should provide financial support to companies according to how many mothers they hire.

Do you think the government should pay companies depending on how many mothers they hire is definitely debatable? I think you're right—it's kind of a hot topic, but it's more original than the one I heard before. I haven't heard this idea before, so it's definitely more original and debatable. All right, thanks. How about Paul?

Paul: There are many governments that have criminal record systems. But for some light and harmless crimes, such as stealing for survival, we shouldn't record them. Society should give those people a second chance.

I do wonder what "give them a second chance" means. That could mean different things. Normally, you do get a second chance—you commit a minor crime, you get out of prison six months later, right? I don't know what the "second chance" means. Just make sure that your wording is very easy to understand. Obviously, in this lesson you only have 15 minutes, and don't worry too much about it. In the first essay, you've got probably a month to think about it, weeks and weeks.

Don't worry, because again, you've only had a short time to think in this class. In your first and second essays, you'll have a little more time to prepare at home. But in the final exam, you'll have to do like you just did today. In the real final exam, you'll have one hour. You get the topic, then you have to think of a main idea and write the essay. So this is good practice for that. I'll say more about the final exam towards the end of the semester.

All right, yeah, I think there were a couple of good ones there, but most of them needed some improvement. If anyone has other main ideas they would like me to look at for their first essay, then feel free to get in touch. Just send me an email, WeChat, or come to my office. I'll be happy to look at your main ideas and give you advice.

But okay, we shall leave it there. And don't forget, in two weeks when I see you again, we'll talk about claims. So the criteria for the main idea is this: for claims, I want you to—obviously, you know, for everything you do in this class—try to be clear. For claims, they should be clear, logical, strong, and balanced. So those are the criteria. Read about that in the handbook, part 2.4.

I don't want to spend a long time lecturing in the next class. I really just want to give you five minutes, and then we'll do some good practice. And then we'll talk about the essay language environment. Pay attention to how it talks about values. Pay attention to how it uses transitions and the structure of a persuasive essay.

Any questions at all? All right, have a nice holiday. I'll see you in two weeks.

(国庆放假啦 😊)

The End